



and there are four official languages—Castilian, Catalan, Galician, and Basque. Each region is **self-governing** and has its own definite flavor, resulting in great diversity among the

Spanish people. For much of its history, Spain was ruled by other civilizations ranging from the Romans to the Moors. Each group has left its **influence** on the culture, arts, and landscape of today.



CASTELLS IN THE SKY

These men making a human castle (*castell*, in Catalan) at a festival in Tarragona are called *castellers*. *Castellers* attend every festival in the region and are also a popular sight on television. Tradition says that the *castell* must be at least eight tiers tall.

BAGPIPES

The music of Galicia in northwest Spain is nothing like the *flamenco* music of Andalusia in the south. *Gaita* (bagpipes) feature strongly because Galicia was once occupied by Celtic people like those who settled in Scotland and Ireland.



FALLAS DE VALENCIA

Spectacular explosions mark the end of Valencia's week-long fire festival. In early March, *ninots*—satirical statues made of cardboard, wood, and plaster—are erected all around the town to be admired and judged. At midnight on March 19, they are blown up, with only the winning *ninot* spared for permanent display in the city's museum.

THE GUGGENHEIM MUSEUM, BILBAO

Opened in 1997, the Guggenheim Museum in Bilbao is one of the most spectacular buildings in the world and a major tourist attraction. This extraordinary collection of sweeping curves covered in thin titanium tiles is 160 ft (50 m) high and spans the area from the city's downtown to the edge of the Nervión River.



BASQUE REGION



The Basque region straddles both France and Spain and has its own distinct identity. Street signs are written in both Castilian (Spain's main Spanish dialect) and the Basque language, Euskara. Euskara is a source of intrigue to scholars because it bears no relationship to any other European language.